

SKILL-BASED COURSE | 12 LEVELS | HTML / CSS / JS

Basic Design Theory Course

Complete Web Page Design Prompt — All 12 Levels

"Design is not decoration. Design is how you see the world."

COURSE OVERVIEW

Course Philosophy

Basic Design Theory is OTS's skill-based visual thinking course. It is not a software tutorial. It is not a Canva class. It is a course about how humans communicate, organise, express, and persuade through the visual world — and how to do it consciously, skillfully, and creatively.

The course has **12 Levels**. It is designed for everyone — from a 10-year-old who wants to understand why some posters look amazing, to a teenager who wants to design for real, to an adult exploring creativity for the first time.

Recommended Tagline

"Learn to See. Then Learn to Design."

The Four Gaps This Course Solves

Seeing Gap	Students look but they do not see. They pass posters and screens every day without noticing what makes them work.
Vocabulary Gap	Students have opinions about design but no language to describe or defend them.
Making Gap	Students want to create but feel they lack talent. Design is a skill, not a gift.
Thinking Gap	Students copy trends but do not understand the principles behind great design.

GLOBAL DESIGN SYSTEM

Design System — Applied to All 12 Level Pages

Critical Note: This course IS about design. The web pages themselves must model great design. Every level page is a design lesson before the content even starts. Each level's page should visually embody the principle being taught.

Typography System

Display Font: Playfair Display — editorial, confident, classic.

Secondary Display: Bebas Neue — bold, structured, modern.

Body Font: Lato or Source Sans 3 — clean, neutral, readable.

Color Philosophy

This course uses a different palette per level — because color is one of the core subjects. Each level page should embody the design principle being taught. See individual level specifications for per-level color identity.

Universal Interaction Rules

All activities usable by tap (mobile) and click (desktop).

Minimum touch target: 48 px × 48 px.

Animations: intentional and purposeful, not decorative noise.

Undo button on all drag/drop and placement activities.

STRUCTURE

Level Architecture — Applied to Every Level Page

Every level page must contain these sections in order:

1. Level Header — number, title, tagline, difficulty, XP, level identity color
2. The Big Question — one provocative question to open the mind
3. Look Around You — real-world observation prompt before teaching
4. The Concept — core teaching with visual examples built into the page
5. See It Live — interactive visual demo of the concept
6. Try It Yourself — creative hands-on activity
7. Judge It — evaluate good vs. bad design using the concept
8. In the Wild — real-world brands and places using this principle
9. Level Challenge — the primary creative challenge
10. Reflection Prompt — one question to push thinking beyond the screen
11. Badge + XP Unlock — completion reward

THE 12 LEVELS

Level-by-Level Design Specifications

LEVEL 1

What Is Design?

Starter

100 XP*"You've been surrounded by it your whole life."***Content, Activities & Interactions**

Design is intentional communication through visual choices. Three questions: What is this for? Who is it for? Does it work? Photo essay of everyday designed objects (traffic sign, medicine bottle, rickshaw). Side-by-side comparisons (clear vs. confusing medicine bottle, easy vs. chaotic menu). 'Redesign This Sign' tool (3 color choices, 2 font sizes, element toggle). Design Observation Journal — Entry 1 saved to portfolio.

Page Design Direction

Warm, inviting, curious aesthetic — like opening a door for the first time. Large photography. Warm orange accents.

LEVEL 2

Color Speaks

Starter

150 XP*"Before words, there was color."***Content, Activities & Interactions**

Color psychology, primary/secondary/tertiary, warm vs. cool, complementary vs. analogous. Color Mood Machine — same scene in different palettes (blues=calm, reds=energy, greens=natural). Paint the Poster — choose color combinations for different film genres, see how meaning shifts. Brand logo color-matching game (6 logos, match to intended emotion). My Color Story — 3 personal colors with explanation saved to portfolio.

Page Design Direction

THIS page IS a color lesson — each section has a different dominant color. Full spectrum gradient identity. Vibrant, alive.

LEVEL 3

The Power of Type

Starter

200 XP*"Words have a look. That look has meaning."***Content, Activities & Interactions**

Typography: serif vs. sans-serif, font personality, hierarchy, legibility vs. readability. 'Same Word, Different World' — DANGER in 8 fonts, users rate danger level. Font Matchmaker — drag fonts to 8 businesses (hospital, law firm, skate shop, etc.). Design a Name Card — first personal design output of the course saved to portfolio.

Page Design Direction

THIS page IS a typography showcase — bold, editorial, type-driven. Deep navy with white. No illustrations — pure typographic design as the visual language.

LEVEL 4
Space is Not Empty

Explorer
250 XP

"What you leave out is as important as what you put in."

Content, Activities & Interactions

White space / negative space. Proximity, grouping, breathing room. Crowded vs. Breathe slider — same content, two versions, transition between them. The Spacer activity — arrange 5 elements using less than 60% of canvas. Before/after comparison. Space Audit of a real-world design saved to portfolio.

Page Design Direction

THIS page is deliberately spacious — cream/off-white, generous margins. The page demonstrates the lesson. Minimalist. Quiet. Confident.

LEVEL 5
Contrast and Attention

Explorer
300 XP

"Your eye goes where it's told."

Content, Activities & Interactions

Light/dark, large/small, bold/thin, color contrast, scale contrast. Eye Tracker Simulation — user taps where eye lands first/second/third, compared to designer's intended path. Contrast Lab — adjust text/background color, size, font weight; live WCAG ratio displayed. Make It Pop — improve low-contrast design using only 3 changes. Real-world: road signs, WCAG accessibility.

Page Design Direction

Pure black background with yellow accents — maximum contrast. Bold, high-contrast, visually aggressive in a controlled and intentional way.

LEVEL 6
Line, Shape and Form

Explorer
350 XP

"Before color, before words — there is shape."

Content, Activities & Interactions

Geometric shapes and psychological associations. Line direction meanings (horizontal=calm, diagonal=movement). Gestalt principles (figure/ground, closure, continuation) in plain language. Shape Personality Test — assign adjectives to 6 shapes, reveal real brand examples. Build a Symbol — create an icon using only basic shapes (no text), for hospital/music/food/school. Logo Anatomy — identify shapes in 5 abstracted logos saved to portfolio.

Page Design Direction

Architectural drawing / blueprint aesthetic. Charcoal + white. Clean lines, grid, precision. Technical drawing feeling. No photography — everything is line and shape.

LEVEL 7

Hierarchy: Who's in Charge?

Challenger

400 XP

"Design without hierarchy is noise."

Content, Activities & Interactions

Visual hierarchy — size, weight, position, color, contrast, space. Z-pattern and F-pattern reading. Hierarchy Revealers — user ranks 6 elements, compared to designer's intended order. Stack the Hierarchy — arrange 6 content pieces by size/position only (no color). Same 5 Elements challenge — same content, different hierarchy choices, compare outputs. Real-world: newspaper layout, web landing pages.

Page Design Direction

Structured, layered. Indigo. Visible hierarchy at every level of the page itself. Pyramid motif. The page's own layout is a hierarchy lesson.

LEVEL 8

Grid and Alignment

Challenger

450 XP

"The invisible skeleton behind every great design."

Content, Activities & Interactions

Grid systems, alignment rules, Rule of Thirds, golden ratio as concept. Aligned vs. Not — toggle grid overlay on/off, see the skeleton. Snap to Grid — arrange 7 elements; indicator turns green when properly aligned. Rule of Thirds — place focal point, compare center vs. third placement. Apply to poster: where should the headline sit? Saved to portfolio.

Page Design Direction

Grid IS the aesthetic — visible grid lines as design element. Mint green. Ordered, structured. The grid on the page mirrors the lesson being taught.

LEVEL 9

Texture, Pattern and Depth

Advanced

500 XP

*"Design has a feel — even on a flat screen."***Content, Activities & Interactions**

Visual texture, pattern, depth (shadow, layering, z-axis). Flat vs. dimensional. Texture Mood Board — rate 12 textures on Formal/Casual and Cold/Warm scales. Layer It — add texture overlay, shadow, and depth to a flat poster. Before/after comparison. Pattern Design — create repeating pattern from 2 shapes + 2 colors; output as gift wrap/fabric. Saved to portfolio.

Page Design Direction

Rich texture backgrounds — paper grain, subtle pattern, depth and shadow throughout. Dark gold. The page itself feels dimensional and tactile.

LEVEL 10

Design for People

Advanced

600 XP

*"The best design is invisible because it works so well."***Content, Activities & Interactions**

Human-centered design, accessibility, inclusive design. Can You Use This? — simulations: color blindness (red-green filter), dyslexia experience, one-hand use, bright sunlight contrast. Redesign for Access — simplify a complex government form for a 12-year-old, non-English speaker, and low-vision user. Accessibility Checklist on own poster design. Who Did You Forget? challenge. Saved to portfolio.

Page Design Direction

Human-centered — photographs and illustrations of diverse real people using design. Hot pink. Warm, inclusive, empathetic energy. Real people, not abstract concepts.

LEVEL 11

Design That Persuades

Advanced

700 XP

*"Design can make you buy, believe, and behave."***Content, Activities & Interactions**

Persuasive design, advertising, dark patterns, designer's responsibility. Dark Pattern Detector — 5 interactive simulations (fake countdown, hidden unsubscribe, confirm-shaming, etc.). The Ethical Choice — design brief with two paths (ethical vs. dark patterns), compare results. Persuasion Audit of a real advertisement — what tools, is it ethical? Saved to portfolio.

Page Design Direction

Advertising/propaganda aesthetic — bold, declarative, persuasive. Deep orange-red. The page itself uses persuasive design techniques — consciously, to teach them.

LEVEL 12

The Design Thinker

MASTER

1000 XP

"Now you see everything differently."

Content, Activities & Interactions

CAPSTONE — apply all 11 principles to one complete brief. Choose: OTS community event poster / student magazine cover / public park signs / local business brand identity. Guided through 6 stages: Define (L1), Color Palette (L2), Typography (L3), Layout (L4/7/8), Contrast+Shape (L5/6), Inclusive Check (L10). Design Decisions Document — explain every choice made. Gold confetti + Design Thinker badge + certificate preview. 12-piece portfolio complete.

Page Design Direction

Portfolio/editorial aesthetic — magazine-quality presentation. Gold + rich dark backgrounds. Premium finish. The eye motif (trained seeing eye). All previous level colors appear as accent dots.

QUICK REFERENCE

Level Identity Quick Reference

Level	Name	Difficulty	Color Hex	XP Reward
Level 1	What Is Design?	Starter	#FF6B35	100 XP
Level 2	Color Speaks	Starter	#FF0080	150 XP
Level 3	The Power of Type	Starter	#1A1A2E	200 XP
Level 4	Space is Not Empty	Explorer	#F8F4EF	250 XP
Level 5	Contrast and Attention	Explorer	#111111	300 XP
Level 6	Line, Shape and Form	Explorer	#2D3436	350 XP
Level 7	Hierarchy: Who's in Charge?	Challenger	#6C5CE7	400 XP
Level 8	Grid and Alignment	Challenger	#00B894	450 XP
Level 9	Texture, Pattern and Depth	Advanced	#B8860B	500 XP
Level 10	Design for People	Advanced	#E84393	600 XP
Level 11	Design That Persuades	Advanced	#FF4500	700 XP
Level 12	The Design Thinker	MASTER	#FFD700	1000 XP

PORTFOLIO SYSTEM

The 12-Piece Visual Portfolio

Unlike Logic Building (which has a skills portfolio), Design Theory has a Visual Portfolio — a collection of creative decisions made across all 12 levels. Every student leaves with real creative output, not just a course certificate.

Level 1	Design Observation Journal Entry
Level 2	My Color Story (3 personal colors + reasoning)
Level 3	My Name Card (first personal design output)
Level 4	Space Audit of a real-world design
Level 5	Make It Pop result (before/after)
Level 6	My Symbol (shape-only icon)
Level 7	Hierarchy Design layout
Level 8	Rule of Thirds poster layout
Level 9	My Pattern Design (tiled output)
Level 10	Accessibility Redesign before/after
Level 11	Persuasion Audit of a real advertisement
Level 12	Final Design Brief + Design Decisions Document

TECHNICAL SPECIFICATIONS

Global Technical Specifications

File Structure

```
basic-design-theory/ ← Root index.html ← Course home / level selector level-01/ ...  
level-12/ ← One folder per level assets/css/ ← global.css, animations.css,  
level-themes.css assets/js/ ← xp-tracker.js, color-tools.js, canvas-tools.js,  
portfolio.js, confetti.js assets/fonts/ ← Preloaded font subsets
```

JavaScript Interactions Required

Color Picker: Native input[type=color] styled, or custom HSL picker.

Drag and Drop: Native HTML5 drag API.

Canvas Drawing: HTML5 Canvas for shape/pattern creation activities.

Image Comparison: Slider-based before/after using CSS clip-path.

Portfolio Storage: localStorage — save design decisions per level.

Contrast Checker: WCAG contrast ratio calculator in pure JS.

Accessibility Simulator: CSS filter for color blindness simulation.

Performance

Page weight per level: under 600 KB. No external UI frameworks.

Google Fonts with font-display: swap.

CSS custom properties for all theme switching — no JS for color changes.

SVG preferred for all diagrammatic/illustrative content.

All design activities usable on a 5-inch phone screen.

OTS-Specific Features

Local examples: Karachi signage, Pakistani packaging, local brands.

Rickshaw art and truck art included as a design movement — pride in local visual culture.

Islamic geometric art and calligraphy cited as valid, celebrated design traditions.

Accessible on low-end Android devices — all interactions work without high processing.

Portfolio export: screenshot or download 12 design decisions as a simple portfolio.

Teacher view: level completion + portfolio entries per student.

Parent view: see what their child designed and created.